

BANGALORE | Lingerin Trouble

A year after the LTTE were wiped out in Sri Lanka, India continues to grapple with the after-effects of that civil war—the burden of refugees who poured into the country. The latest Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) report states that as of December 31, 2009, there are 72,969 Lankan refugees living in 115 refugee camps in Tamil Nadu and one camp in Orissa. There are also 26,729 refugees living in camps they set up themselves after registering at the nearest police stations. The MHA report observes that 3,03,061 refugees have entered India since the beginning of the ethnic conflict in July 1983. The ministry says 99,469 refugees have been repatri-



SRI LANKAN REFUGEES AT A CAMP IN TRICHY

ated to Sri Lanka up to March 1995. Some of them have returned to their country while others have left India for other destinations. The Indian Government has spent a total of Rs 479 crore for providing relief and accommodation to the refugees from July 1983 to December 2009.

by Stephen David

BUZZ OF THE WEEK

First, new BJP President Nitin Gadkari fainted at a rally in Delhi. Then, soon after his appointment as BJP Madhya Pradesh chief, Prabhat Jha also passed out as if in sync with Gadkari. Surely the BJP needs a health check.

PATNA | The Opposition Has Landed



KRISHNA MURARI KUSHAN

If you can't do it alone, cobble a team to do it. This seems to be the new mantra for some leaders in Bihar who have teamed up to turn the tables on Nitish Kumar. Former Union ministers Digvijay Singh, Naagmani and Akhilesh Prasad

OPPOSITION LEADERS AT THE KISAN CONCLAVE

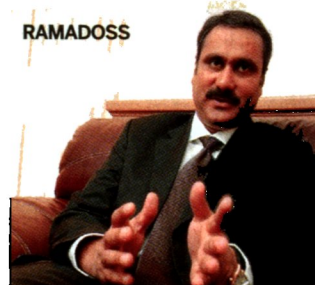
Singh (both from RJD), LJP leader Surajbhan, JD(U) rebels Prabhunath Singh and Rajeev Ranjan Singh alias Lallan Singh have teamed up with the one-point agenda of preventing Nitish from becoming chief minister for a second term. They got together at a Kisan Mahapanchayat (farmer's conclave) at Patna's Gandhi Maidan where they claimed that if Nitish is voted back to power, he will implement the Bataidari (land to the tillers) bill. The land issue assumes enormous electoral impact in Bihar—it is believed to have been the cause of the NDA's defeat in 13 of the 18 Assembly seats that went to the bypolls in September 2009.

by Amitabh Srivastava

CHENNAI | Poll Dance

After splitting up in June 2008, the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) wants to get cosy with the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) again. The PMK's urgency to get back into the DMK-led front comes from a bid to get Anbumani Ramadoss, son of PMK founder S. Ramadoss, re-elected to the Rajya Sabha. Ramadoss' tenure ends in June after he earned the seat with the help of the DMK. The PMK has only 18 MLAs, 16 short of the

RAMADOSS



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number required to send Anbumani into the Upper House. The PMK can't ask AIADMK chief Jayalalithaa for her support in the matter. This because soon after the Lok Sabha polls, the PMK had charged the AIADMK with trying to implicate its top leaders in a false case. Now, the DMK has called for a high-level party meeting to discuss the Rajya Sabha polls and facilitate Ramadoss' re-election.

by Lakshmi Subramanian